

essential challenge... When we start looking at things in the future, it might require major changes in your capabilities, your processes, your skills, and a number of other factors.

Q: Some of the big AI companies are saying, ‘Why are you worried about job losses? This is the end of the workweek; AI will increase productivity, increase GDP; you will have a universal basic income, you can go to work two days a week and be in the Bahamas the rest of the time.’ You know, this is utopia...

A: So some of it is true, and some of it is not. Keep in mind the bigger context of what is happening in the world and tech. Right now, there’s a huge backlash against tech...especially [in] the countries that dominate tech—the US and China. There has been a huge backlash in society, from government, and they’re trying to basically control the power of the tech companies. The tech companies are doing all they can to ease the hype, to reduce the stress, reduce the fear, and basically tell people, ‘Don’t get alarmed, don’t worry, nothing is going to change, or it’ll be just making things better and easier for you.’

I think that’s disingenuous. And it’s not really correct. Yes, it will make things easier. But at the same time, it will change things quite dramatically in some sectors. And it is up to us to be able to decide how you plan for the changes. If you take, for example, sectors like law, a lot of what young lawyers do is basically go through old cases, identify precedents, build some arguments for current cases... A lot of that today can be done effectively, sometimes even better than humans, by AI-based systems. If you take a little bit more physical domain, let’s say truck drivers... In America, in many of the highway routes, some companies are essentially using automated trucks; the driver’s still there for safety reasons right now (but not for long)... and usually takes over in the first few miles and in the last few miles. As the number of truck drivers is reduced—and you see this already in the army and air force, where there aren’t as many fighter pilots [as

earlier as] it’s all drone based—what do you do with a 40-year-old truck driver? You might say there are plenty of jobs in looking after human beings... How easy is it to take a 40-year-old male truck driver and make this person a childcare minder? These are huge social transition issues and I don’t think we have the answers for that. These are important answers and questions that businesses have to grapple with. And at the same time, the government has to also step in and provide some support, some regulatory guidance, and in some cases, even direct support for transitioning of skills. I think skills transition is a major issue ahead of us.

Q: I want to go back to something you mentioned early on in the answer about this backlash that tech companies are facing. And so they’re trying to soften the blow. But you have talked about the difference between

computing and AI. Computing is more co-pilot—it assists you, whereas this new set of generative AI is learning, is using you to learn, and then eventually it is going to be better than you...

A: It’s very important to understand where we are with AI skills. How good is AI today? If you look at the traditional cognitive tasks—typically tasks linked to recognition

of patterns and data, whatever kind of patterns they might be, whether it’s medical images, machine data, pictures of anything—any kind of pattern recognition in data, which is a large part of what human beings do, today is done better by machines. And this you see, for example, in many countries right now, immigration is done on facial recognition. Why? Because the machine can recognise a face better than a human being. That is done better by machines since 2017.

Cognitive and human reasoning—that’s the part where typically human beings did better, because a lot of common sense knowledge that machines have difficulty in understanding like, let’s say, if I give you

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